against the Kafirs. His invasions ranging from Laghman to Alishang, led to the conversion of around seventy valleys to Islam. After having conquered the Tajau and Nijrau valleys in the Panjshir area, the Jihadis established a fort at Islamabad at the confluence of the Alishang and Alingar rivers. They continued raiding up to Alishang and made their last effort against the non-Muslims of Alingar, fighting up to Mangu (the modern border between Pashai and Ashkun-speaking areas).[§]

Babur's Narrative Continues

But somehow, Pīr Sulṭān failed to guide Babur and his men through. Maybe his old age had become taxing, or the deep snow had an impact. This failure robbed Qāsim Beg's peace—as the very route was suggested by him—and Babur had chosen it although the majority had a different opinion. To not lose respect, he along with his son dismounted from the horse. They began to trample the snow down. Eventually, a faint footprint on the road appeared, and he took the lead.

They kept on riding, hoping to reach their destination the quickest possible way. But the destiny had other plans. The winter snow kept turning deeper. One, it was so deep, and the way became so uncertain that they couldn't even take a stride. No help could come then. They had no choice but to return to a place where they could at least find food and supplies. They dismounted at such a place. There, Babur sent out around seventy good men down to valley to find a Hazāra, who could show them the right road ahead. Babur was hoping that someone would be wintering down in the valley. But against Babur's hope, no one was found.

Once more Babur had to look upon Sulṭān Pashāī to show the road. Putting his faith in Allah, Babur under his guidance, took the same road. They reached back from where they had lost.

It has been mentioned in the *Baburnama* that it was one of the most stressful phases of his life, during which abundant misery had befallen him. He composed the following couplet expressing this phase of stress:[*]

> Is there one cruel turn of Fortune's wheel unseen of me?
>
> Is there a pang, a grief my wounded heart has missed?

The path was indeed very tough. They kept on riding for nearly a week, crushing away the thick sheet of snow on the way. They could hardly cover a score of miles by then.